

August 12, 1943

The Secretary

Mr. Paul

Mr. Luxford mentioned to me your request for a memorandum regarding some of the background on the proposal for the evacuation of Jewish refugees from Rumania.

In the latter part of June, the State Department forwarded to us certain cables received from Bern, Switzerland, relating to this matter. In substance, the World Jewish Congress in Switzerland is attempting to work out a way to evacuate up to 70,000 Jews from Rumania at a cost of approximately \$170,000. These funds would be paid to the Rumanian officials in local currency by well-to-do Rumanian Jewish merchants who would be reimbursed at black market rates either in dollars or Swiss francs to be blocked and held in trust for them until after the war. The entire operation would be directed from Switzerland by an agent of the World Jewish Congress, who, in turn, would work through underground channels with prominent members of the Jewish Congress in Rumania.

Shortly thereafter Dr. Mahun Goldmann and James Wise of the American Jewish Congress called to discuss this matter in a preliminary way with us. On July 15 a conference was held with Messrs. Reams, Meltzer and Kuppinger of the State Department concerning this proposal. Mr. Reams, Foreign Service Officer, presently assigned to the European Division, and also assigned as State Department's refugee expert, threw cold water on the proposal on the grounds that it would be probably impossible to work out as a practical matter satisfactory arrangements with the Rumanian authorities and that the transportation of any persons evacuated could only be arranged with German consent which would not be forthcoming. He further pointed out the fact that under the provisions of the British White Paper, only about 30,000 Jews can be admitted to Palestine and he said he did not know of any other areas to which the remaining Jews could be evacuated since the Turkish Government has refused entry to Jewish refugees and so far as the North Africa area is concerned, the military authorities have, for military reasons, been unwilling to permit their entry into Africa. As a matter of fact, it was indicated that the United States Chiefs of Staff had decided that refugees could not be admitted even in Dakar for military reasons, but that it was believed that the President was about to overrule this decision.